A New Dawn

On 13 August, at the first blush of dawn, Berliners woke up in a city separated by a closely guarded border. In the general confusion – and with rumours swirling around – the public sought answers to the most pressing questions: was the barrier temporary and why were the Americans taking no action? The German people were completely unprepared for what Ulbricht had done. Many reacted initially with shock, upset about friends and family on the other side of the barbed wire. ‘I was very shaken when I heard the words “Die Grenze ist Geschlossen” at the Brandenburg Gate in the early hours of that Sunday morning,’ says Kellett-Long, who embarked on a sortie of the city. ‘After that, there was very little time for contemplation. And it should not be forgotten how often the lying word “temporary” was used in official announcements, none of which mentioned a wall.’

Honecker remained buoyant throughout Sunday, enjoying the sensation of a job well done:

Even the Allies in West Berlin were taken by surprise. However much one may try to twist things around in retrospect, the irrefutable fact remains that despite the very comprehensive preparations which were necessary to make it a success, the erection of the antifascist defence wall came as a complete surprise to our enemies.1

Whether there was an egregious intelligence failure on the part of the Western allies, or a deliberate lack of interest is still open to debate. For sure, it is known that none of the CIA agents – working in East Berlin under the guise of US diplomats or regular soldiers – predicted events, and, remarkably, after the Wall was built there was no public discussion in the United States about the CIA intelligence failure, nor did any member of the US government complain that the secret service had not received warning